

Talk Tonight

Get closer to relatives and friends with the best webcams on the market

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You've noticed it: webcams are everywhere these days. At least, they should be: they're useful, they're fun, and they're cheap now—barring the few that have some really cool features. Instant messengers—Yahoo! Messenger and Windows Live! Messenger included—now have the embedded video chat option. VoIP-based applications like videoconferencing use webcams so face-to-face meetings can take place in virtual space. Videoconferencing is also used by SoHos as a cheap and effective medium of communication between various branches.

If you're in the market for a webcam, we encourage you to read what follows—we'll tell you all about what's available, while also helping you make a purchase decision. And here's our customary cautionary statement: don't just take what your dealer dishes out as the best-selling cam!

Our categories here are Vanilla Webcams—the really basic ones; Mid-range Webcams, which are probably the most popular; Performance Webcams, for the discerning; and The Niche Category—for those who want, well, something different.

VANILLA WEBCAMS

This first category comprises webcams below Rs 800. Cheap, yes? They offer just basic functionality, as you might expect, and are just about adequate for video chat.

This lower end of the test spectrum was populated by 10 models from four brands. Logitech and Intex contested with one contender each, and Zebronic sent in two. Tech-Com features prominently, with six models.

Features

Manual focus is standard in this category. A few webcams—the Tech-Com SSD-644K, Tech-Com SSD-645K, and the Intex IT 305 WC—support digital zoom, but this tends to be of little help; the images captured are grainy.

Night Vision

Several webcams in this category feature night vision technology (not to be confused with IR NightVision)—they have bright white LEDs in the front, which act as light sources in low-light conditions. This doesn't make much difference when it's dark, but it improves capture quality in dim lighting.

The Tech-Com SSD-644K has a manual switch on the camera to power the LEDs; the others have

automatic LED brightness control, which varies according to the ambient light. This ensures that the light on the subject is bright enough. The option to override the automatic brightness control for the LED is there in the drivers, just in case the bright LEDs hurt your eyes.

The Snapshot Button

A snapshot switch is useful—you can take still shots in conjunction with the application bundled with the webcam.



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